

SOURCES OF ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

Trace -> context -> chronology -> corroboration -> qualified reconstruction

Core evidence rail | Archaeology | Epigraphy | Numismatics | Texts | Foreign accounts | Science | Answer method

Read each panel as: definition -> named evidence -> inference -> limitation.

PANEL 1/14 — FROM TRACE TO DEFENSIBLE HISTORY

SURVIVING TRACE

- identity/authenticity
- provenance or archaeological provenience
- date and transmission
- author/audience/purpose/genre
- comparison and corroboration
- silence and alternatives

QUALIFIED HISTORICAL CLAIM

RULE: texts are not transparent facts; archaeology is not self-interpreting.

PANEL 2/14 — SOURCE UNIVERSE

ARCHAEOLOGY | settlement, technology, foodways | context/sampling
EPIGRAPHY | acts, rulers, donors, institutions | formula/elite survival
NUMISMATICS | authority, metrology, circulation | hoard/movement bias
LITERATURE | norm, memory, ideas, vocabulary | genre/redaction
FOREIGN | routes, comparison, synchronism | standpoint/translation
VISUAL/ORAL | patronage, iconography, memory | convention/performance
SCIENCE | ranges, diet, mobility, environment | sample/baseline limits
NO FIXED HIERARCHY: fit the source to the question.

PANEL 3/14 — ORIGIN AND CHRONOLOGY RAIL

PREHISTORY | archaeology dominates
HARAPPAN PROTOHISTORY | c. 2600–1900 BCE; script undeciphered
VEDIC/POST-VEDIC | layered oral-textual traditions + archaeology
EARLY HISTORIC | readable inscriptions, coins, cities, many texts
3rd c. BCE | Ashokan corpus gives firm epigraphic anchors
1837 | Prinsep's decisive Brahmi decipherment step
MODERN METHOD | archaeometry, bioarchaeology, digital corpora

PANEL 4/14 — ARCHAEOLOGICAL METHOD

SURVEY → SITE → EXCAVATION → STRATIGRAPHY → ASSEMBLAGE → INTERPRETATION
vertical trends ≠ sequence | horizontal exposure ≠ selected phase layout
lower undisturbed layer generally earlier
BUT pits, intrusion, erosion and redeposition can disturb sequence
artefact → industry → assemblage → archaeological culture
CAUTION: archaeological culture ≠ race/language/tribe/dynasty/state

PANEL 5/14 — DATING AND SCIENTIFIC EVIDENCE

RELATIVE: stratigraphy | typology | seriation | cross-dating | palaeography
CHRONOMETRIC:
• radiocarbon → calibrated range for organic death
• TL → last suitable heating
• OSL → last sufficient light exposure
• isotopes → diet/mobility with baselines
• aDNA → ancestry/relatedness with sample limits
RULE: result dates a sample and association, not automatically a civilisation.

PANEL 6/14 — INSCRIPTIONS AND DECIPHERMENT

EPIGRAPHY = inscriptions | PALAEOGRAPHY = old writing/scripts
Brahmi: normally left to right; parent of many later scripts
Kharoshthi: right to left; north-west/Gandhara
Ashokan corpus: mainly Prakrit-Brahmi; north-west also Kharoshthi,
Greek and Aramaic settings
1837 Prinsep: cumulative comparative decipherment, not solitary intuition
GENRES:
edict → policy claim, not automatic implementation
prashasti → genealogy/ideology, but eulogy and omission
land grant → legal-fiscal act, not uniform enforcement
donation → donor/institution, but selection and survival bias

PANEL 7/14 — COINS AND NUMISMATICS

COIN = metal + weight + manufacture + legend + icon + die + wear + context
YIELD: issuer, title, relative sequence, standard, technology, circulation
HOARD: selected deposit; latest issue supplies a post-issue boundary
OVERSTRIKE: undertype earlier than or contemporary with overtype
Jogalthembi: Nahapana undertypes counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni
LIMITS: distribution ≠ sovereignty; abundance ≠ total prosperity;
debasement can reflect scarcity, demand or policy, not only collapse.

PANEL 8/14 — LITERARY SOURCE FAMILIES

VEDIC | ritual, kinship, economy vocabulary | oral layers
EPIC/PURANA | memory, values, genealogy | recession/interpolation
BUDDHIST/JAINA | monastery, merchant, town, doctrine | sectarian/dialectic frame
SANGAM | chiefs, war, love, work, exchange | bardic/dating issues
DHARMASHASTRA | norm, property, family, gender | prescription ≠ practice
ARTHASHASTRA | statecraft model | not one-reign transcript
COURT/BIOGRAPHY | patronage, ideology, political memory | praise/aesthetic convention
TEXTUAL TIME:
composition → performance → addition/redaction → recession
→ surviving manuscript → critical edition/translation → interpretation

PANEL 9/14 — FOREIGN, VISUAL, ORAL AND LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE

FOREIGN ACCOUNT:
route + duration + purpose + language + informants + audience
• direct observation/hearsay + translation/survival
Megasthenes | Periplus | Faxian | Xuanzang | Arab-Persian witnesses
VISUAL/MATERIAL:
architecture, sculpture, painting, pottery, seals → patronage, technology,
ritual and representation; image ≠ photograph, style ≠ exact date.
LINGUISTIC/ORAL:
loanwords, place names, genealogy, performed memory
language ≠ race/ancestry/polity; performance reshapes memory.

PANEL 10/14 — TRIANGULATION

MATCH chronology → geography → scale → independence → source purpose
TEXT CLAIM + INSCRIPTION/COIN + ARCHAEOLOGICAL CONTEXT + SCIENTIFIC RANGE
|
v
CONVERGENCE / CONFLICT / RESIDUAL SILENCE
|
v
BOUNDED HISTORICAL INFERENCE
Pali money terms + punch-marked coins → monetisation, regionally uneven
Sangam ports + Tamil-Brahmi + imported wares → connectivity, not total volume
Ashokan edicts + Pataliputra + classical testimony → complementary Mauryan views

PANEL 11/14 — ARCHIVE BIAS, FORGERY AND PRESERVATION

OVER-REPRESENTED: rulers, donors, literate elites, stone, metal, monuments
UNDER-REPRESENTED: labour, women, perishable life, oral communities
SILENCE TEST: expected production? survival? recognition? adequate search?
UNPROVENANCED OBJECT: material/style may survive: contextual history is lost
FORGERY CONTROL: material, script, custody, comparison and publication
INSTITUTIONS: ASI, museums and archives preserve evidence; catalogues and
digital records remain revisable source layers.

PANEL 12/14 — WHAT SOURCES REVEAL

POLITY | edicts, prashastis, grants, coins, court texts
ECONOMY | settlements, workshops, coins, ports, merchant/donor records
SOCIETY | houses, burials, normative texts, donations, literature
RELIGION | ritual texts, monasteries, icons, donations, architecture
GENDER | prescriptions + female donations + household/material evidence
ENVIRONMENT | pollen, seeds, fauna, soils, isotopes, palaeochannels
RULE: one source answers one dimension; cross-reading controls elite bias.

PANEL 13/14 — PQ AND PRELIMS TRAPS

2018 GS-1: Chinese and Arab travellers → value + standpoint + corroboration
2023 Q46: literary attribution; local official key unavailable → do not invent
2024 Q55: site/state/type cells; official key B (rows 2 and 3)
TRAPS:
manuscript date ≠ composition | prashasti ≠ neutral chronicle
coin distribution ≠ empire | radiocarbon ≠ exact event year
aDNA ≠ language/caste/religion | absence ≠ non-existence
foreign ≠ objective | archaeology ≠ self-explaining

PANEL 14/14 — EXECUTABLE ANSWER METHOD

1. Decode directive and historical dimension.
2. Select source class fitted to that claim.
3. Write CLAIM + NAMED EVIDENCE → ANALYSIS → QUALIFICATION.
4. Add independent corroboration at matching time/place/scale.
5. State silence or residual uncertainty.
6. End with a graded verdict, not "all sources are important".
QUALIFIED CONCLUSION:
Ancient Indian history is strongest when independent archives constrain one
another without erasing genre, context, survival bias or uncertainty.

QUALIFIED VERDICT: independent convergence strengthens reconstruction without erasing context, bias or uncertainty.